

often not working from a firsthand knowledge of the literature and its background. For example, the account given by Gingras of the engendering of Galahad (p. 407) declares that he was conceived thanks to the machinations of Brisane, who persuaded Lancelot to drink a special potion (true) and made him believe she was Guinevere (false). In the text it is not Brisane but the daughter of Pellés Lancelot is deceived into taking for the queen. On page 150 Gingras unwisely overstates the virginity of the Lady of the Lake, as some time after Lancelot has left the Lake, she comes to heal him from his madness and tells Guinevere that she must now leave as *force d'amors* is taking her back to her *ami* (*Lancelot*, ed. Alexandre Micha, 9 vols. [Geneva, 1978–93], 8:462). Considerable attention is devoted to Merlin's role in the *Lancelot-Grail* cycle and elsewhere in both the books under review, but, strangely, neither mentions the version of Merlin's birth given in most manuscripts of the Prose *Lancelot* at the beginning of the account of Lancelot's childhood in the Lake (*Lancelot*, ed. Micha, 7:38–41). Here Merlin, in contrast with the baptized Merlin of Robert de Boron, is presented as the son of an incubus and never baptized; thus the Lady of the Lake is justified in shutting him up after she has learned her magic from him (see Elspeth Kennedy, *Lancelot and the Grail* [Oxford, 1986], pp. 112–15 and 309).

Christine Ferlampin-Acher declares that her aim is to track down the concept of the marvelous as it is to be found in medieval romance itself, in the way it is written for an ideal reader built into the text, in order to determine how far it is possible to define a marvelous independent of the ordinary individual reader, whether medieval or modern. She would, however, admit that each reader molds into the common experience imposed by the text his or her own imaginary universe. She declares that what concerns us here is not absolute belief but the thought that something might be true, an attitude typical of much medieval romance. She has taken as her base for this study the prose romances of the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries. Chapter 2 examines the diversity of medieval time, exploring different levels of time in *Perceforest* and *Perlesvaus*. Chapter 3 deals with the interplay between real and imaginary places, between this world and the otherworld, hell and paradise. Chapter 4 looks at ladies with magical powers, concentrating on *Perceforest* and *Artus de Bretagne*. Chapter 5 examines soothsayers and enchanters, then Merlin. Chapter 6 explores the darker or more ambiguous beings, such as witches, demons, and elves like Zephir in *Perceforest*. Chapters 7 and 8 deal with monsters, strange beasts, and marvelous objects.

The starting point for this exploration of the means used to elicit a certain type of reaction to the marvelous from whoever reads the romance is an interesting one. The chapters devoted to the fourteenth-century romances, which have up till now received less attention than they deserve, are particularly welcome, and the book in general has suggested new lines of research that I would like to explore. However, as often happens today in books based on doctoral theses, the author tries to cover a wider area of long texts than she can have close personal knowledge of at this stage. Thus, for example, it is not true, as stated on page 164, that little is said of Lancelot's childhood in the Lake; an account of his education, his meeting with a former vassal of his father, and his quarrel with his tutor is given. Lohot is described on page 24 as "le fol d'Arthur" in the *Perlesvaus*, but he was in fact his son (*Perlesvaus*, line 6345). Nevertheless, the book contains much of interest.

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GIOACCHINO DA FIORE, *Dialoghi sulla prescienza divina e la predestinazione degli eletti*, ed. and trans. (into Italian) Gian Luca Potestà. (Opera di Gioacchino da Fiore: Testi e Strumenti, 14.) Rome: Viella, 2001. Paper. Pp. 159. €16.01.

In 1995 Gian Luca Potestà published his Latin edition of Joachim's text (*Dialogi de prescientia Dei et predestinatione electorum*, Opera Omnia 4/1, Fonti per la Storia dell'Italia

Medievale, Antiquitates, 4), prefaced by a useful *presentazione* of the complex affiliations of the publication series of the Centro internazionale di studi gioachimiti by Kurt-Victor Selge. The present volume reproduces the Latin text of that edition without the *apparatus criticus* (*Dialogi*, pp. 37–61), the bibliography of patristic authors and works cited by Joachim (*Dialogi*, pp. 144–45), the index of proper names (*Dialogi*, pp. 155–58), or the index of important terms (*Dialogi*, pp. 147–53) in the 1995 edition, but with a new scholarly bibliography, the original index of biblical citations in the work, a new introduction aimed at a broader readership, and Potestà's own excellent facing Italian translation of the Latin text.

Potestà argues persuasively that the *Dialogi* is an early work, most likely dating from the period 1183–84, about the time of the *De prophetia ignota*, thus representing an important early stage of the exegete's literary career and the development of his thought. In one important respect it is also representative of Joachim's distinctive exegetical style; although he follows Scripture (especially the key texts in Rom. 8 and 9) and the Latin Fathers (but not Augustine's anti-Pelagian works nor the Carolingians or Anselm), he puts his own distinctive stamp on a problem that had teased ninth-century theologians, had been extensively revived in the twelfth century, and continued into the thirteenth and fourteenth. But the *Dialogi*, even in the reprisal of some of its points in Joachim's later *De articulis fidei*, seems to have played no role in later Scholastic discussions of the topic, from commentaries on Peter Lombard to Thomas Aquinas, Peter Aureol, and Gregory of Rimini.

The work is most sensibly read, then, in a specifically Joachite context, that is, as a distinctive, if idiosyncratic, example of twelfth-century monastic theology, a reading that Bernard McGinn has recently endorsed ("Ratio and Visio: Reflections on Joachim of Fiore's Place in Twelfth-Century Theology," in *Gioacchino da Fiore tra Bernardo di Clairvaux e Innocenzo III*, ed. Roberto Rusconi [Rome, 2001], pp. 26–46). Joachim's emphasis on God's mercy toward the humble, toward Jacob rather than Esau, is consistent with his monastic perspective and his familiarity with and admiration for the work of Bernard of Clairvaux. Salvation is then a sign of divine mercy shown to the elect, while the judgment of the reprobate descends on them because of their evil use of free will and their consequent *superbia*. As Potestà puts it, "Joachim affirms that God predestines the elect, having foreknowledge of them as such, while, as far as regards the reprobate, God has foreknown, but not predestined, them" (p. 8), thus avoiding the problem of double predestination.

Joachim also emphasizes God's foreknowledge from all eternity and history as the rational playing out of a divine logic, comprehensible only through our perception of the *ordo rationis* that governs it. Here, early in his remarkable exegetical career, is a first glimpse of Joachim's turning to Scripture as a key to the meaning and plan of history.

In the long run, Joachim's assertion that divine foreknowledge and predestination can be understood, not, as Augustine had asserted, as an inscrutable mystery, but as manifestations of divine mercy and justice leads the exegete to a remarkably hopeful view of the prospects of salvation. In book 1 Benedict asks Joachim about the prospects of salvation of that innumerable crowd of ignorant people, unlearned, undisciplined, and even brutish, and whether these might be counted among God's elect. Joachim responds, citing the book of Job (1.14) and Ps. 35.7 as proof texts, that "if these men are not wicked, if they do not hate their neighbor, if they do not violate the peace . . . and if they fear the fires of hell—in the same way that beasts are disciplined by the rod—if they are obedient to their priests, whether in preserving their innocence or doing penance, within the limits of their weakness and simplicity, these, too, have the hope of being saved, according as how God multiplies his mercy" (pp. 72–73). For Joachim, reform might open all doors, especially those of salvation, even for the least likely of human prospects. The humble and the wretched of

the earth, in Calabria and elsewhere, might also have their part in the *ordo rationis* of salvation.

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MATTHEW S. GORDON, *The Breaking of a Thousand Swords: A History of the Turkish Military of Samarra (A.H. 200–275/815–889 C.E.)*. (SUNY Series in Medieval Middle East History.) Albany, N.Y.: State University of New York Press, 2001. Pp. xx, 303; 7 black-and-white illustrations and 2 maps.

The Turkish military of Samarra, the capital of the Abbasid caliphate for the indicated period, has mostly been treated in the framework of what Gordon calls the “mamluk paradigm,” that is, in a body of literature that deals with the institution of military slavery within Islamic civilization. In some cases, this institution is seen as having emerged in just the Samarran period to continue basically unchanged until its final demise in the beginning of the nineteenth century C.E. Therefore, a case study of the situation in Samarra is most welcome. Gordon makes it clear from the outset that he does not want to contribute to this “set of wide-angle snapshots, bold in sweep and occasionally imprecise in detail” (p. 6). He thus warns his readers that he is not going to treat any of the more general questions surrounding the institution of military slavery in Islamic history: “no attempt will be made to explore the reasons behind the use of Turkish soldiers . . . [n]or will any attempt be made to compare the Samarran case with that of subsequent periods” (p. 8). This self-restriction is indeed what informs the book throughout: it is mainly a very close description of what the sources (mostly the well-known works of Arabic historiography) tell us about the Samarran Turks.

The sources are treated with some caution. Gordon shows that he has taken note of the debate surrounding the use of *akhbār*-style texts, but he also avoids an overly critical attitude. This is well in tune with his down-to-earth approach to general questions. The book offers some important results. Gordon shows that the Turkish leaders, above all the central figures of the first generation of slave generals, had interests that differed very much from the rank and file and even the lower officers. Further, he takes great care to differentiate between the first and the second generation of Turkish military leaders; the second generation, who took their position as a heritage from their fathers, mostly did not wield as much power as their predecessors had. A third very useful difference Gordon insists on is that between the Turkish troops and others; here he shows that some conclusions have been too hastily drawn (concerning Christopher Beckwith’s theory on the *chākariya* corps). Besides, and perhaps Gordon does not stress this point sufficiently, the Turks were the only part of the Samarran caliphal army to be composed of a majority of slaves: the Maghāribā troops (from western Egypt) and those from the Ferghana valley and other regions of eastern Iran and Transoxiana probably were not. Gordon also points out, although not before appendix B, that some leaders of Turkish slave troops apparently had entered the caliphal service on their own accord, being freeborn nobles. Thus, as a general conclusion one might say that the book is an important contribution to the debate on the importance of military slavery in early Islamic society in that it adds a number of caveats and adduces details that cannot be ignored in the general debate.

Gordon might, however, have addressed some questions more boldly, for instance, the question of the relationship between retainer troops and the Turkish guard, which is relegated to appendix A. The self-restriction noted above means that he does not even address the question of what might have been the initial idea behind the large-scale acquisition of military slaves by al-Mu’taṣim, and consequently the question of whether the military leaders surrounding the prince and later caliph might have functioned like the leadership